

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT OF COUNTRY

Cultural Considerations for Water Safety Education | All Year Levels

First Nations perspectives on waterways and Country.
Culturally responsive practice for CALD communities.
Cross-curriculum priority: ATSI Histories & Cultures.

Acknowledgement of Country

We acknowledge the **Traditional Custodians** of the lands and waters on which we teach and learn. We pay our respects to Elders past, present, and emerging. We recognise that waterways — rivers, lakes, estuaries, coastlines, and seas — hold deep **cultural, spiritual, and practical significance** for First Nations peoples across Australia. In teaching water safety, we acknowledge that we are working within landscapes that are not simply natural features — they are Country.

Why Cultural Considerations Matter in Water Safety Education

First Nations Relationships with Water

For Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples, waterways are not simply recreational spaces or safety hazards — they are places of deep cultural, spiritual, and ecological significance embedded in Songlines, Dreamtime stories, and custodianship responsibilities maintained for over 60,000 years. Respectful teaching acknowledges that Country — including water — is alive with meaning.

First Nations Over-Representation in Drowning Data

Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples experience significantly higher drowning rates than non-Indigenous Australians. This is a **structural and historical inequity**, not a reflection on individual behaviour. Contributing factors include:

- Historical exclusion from public swimming pools — creating generational skill gaps
- Higher rates of rural and remote living near unpatrolled waterways
- Limited access to swimming lessons in remote communities
- Language barriers to mainstream water safety messaging

Always frame First Nations over-representation as a structural inequity requiring structural solutions — not as a cultural or behavioural deficit.

Culturally Responsive Classroom Practice

Context	Recommended approach ✓	Avoid ✗
Discussing CALD or First Nations drowning over-representation	Frame as structural inequity. Acknowledge historical factors. Connect to community solutions.	Framing as individual or cultural failing.
Teaching about dangerous waterways (rivers, billabongs)	Acknowledge these are also sites of cultural significance. Teach safety without dismissing the value of the place.	Describing waterways only as hazards.
Engaging First Nations students	Invite (not demand) sharing of community knowledge. Treat cultural knowledge with the same respect as a primary source.	Putting students on the spot as "representatives" of all First Nations peoples.
CALD students and families with limited swim access	Frame limited swim access as a structural issue. Provide information about free and low-cost programs.	Implying families who have not prioritised swimming lessons are being negligent.
Discussing BeachSafe app and lifeguard patrols	Acknowledge that lifeguard infrastructure is not evenly distributed in remote communities.	Implying that people at unpatrolled locations simply make bad choices.

Classroom Protocols & Further Resources

■ Key protocols for integrating First Nations knowledge:

- Name the specific Country and Custodians for your local waterways — use aiatsis.gov.au/explore/map-indigenous-australia
- Invite (not demand) First Nations students to share community knowledge
- Use resources developed in collaboration with community — not third-party summaries
- Frame the unit as: "Western safety frameworks and First Nations custodianship traditions can both inform how we approach water safety"
- Consider inviting an Elder or community member to speak about their relationship with local waterways

Resource	Purpose	URL
AIATSIS Map of Indigenous Australia	Identify Traditional Custodians of local waterways	aiatsis.gov.au
Reconciliation Australia	Culturally responsive practice resources for schools	reconciliation.org.au/schools/
LSV Multicultural Safety	Community swim programs and CALD resources	lsv.com.au/community/multicultural-safety/
RLSSA First Nations Programs	National data and programs including Deadly Sista Girlz	royallifesaving.com.au/programs
Victorian Curriculum — Cross-curriculum priorities	ATSI Histories and Cultures alignment guidance	victoriancurriculum.vcaa.vic.edu.au